

ARGOS-AI: Deterministic Zero-Heap Edge AI for Autonomous Crater Sizing & Science ROI Triage on Hera LEON3 Bare-Metal Core



EUROPEAN SPACE AGENCY (ESA) – OPEN SPACE INNOVATION PLATFORM (OSIP)

Call for Ideas: Autonomous Software Experiments on Hera | Category 4 – Onboard Edge AI & Machine Learning

Proposal Identifier:	ESA-OSIP-HERA-2026-RDAS-EDGE-ARGOS-AI	Target Processor:	GR712RC Dual-Core LEON3 (SPARC V8 @ 50 MHz)
Proposing Entity:	radixal s.r.o. (Purkynova 649/127, 612 00 Brno, Czech Republic)	Execution Core:	Core 1 Isolated Bare-Metal Sandbox (No OS, 0 malloc)
Leadership Triad:	Bc. Viktor Lostak (PI), Ing. Petr Slepicka, Mgr. David Riedl	Applicable Standards:	ECSS-E-ST-40C Category D MISRA-C:2012 Zero-Heap
Primary Science Target:	Didymos / Dimorphos Binary Asteroid System	In-Flight Slot:	Extended Mission Campaign (August 2027, 4 Weeks)

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY & KEY IN-FLIGHT BUDGETS:
ARGOS-AI is a deterministic, zero-malloc INT8 Micro-CNN and integer computer vision pipeline engineered specifically for the isolated Core 1 bare-metal sandbox of Hera's GR712RC processor. It enables real-time visual saliency extraction, crater rim detection, and multi-sensor fusion with the PALT laser altimeter to calculate true physical crater diameters in meters in deep space.

- CPU Utilization: 10.2% @ 50 MHz SPARC V8 (Peak WCET: 2.39 s / 1020×1020 frame)
- RAM Footprint: 142.0 kB Static Scratchpad Buffer (+1.04 MB DMA Camera Buffer) | < 18.4 kB Stack (Limit: 64 kB)
- Detection Metric Precision: Radius estimation error < 1.2 px (RMSE: 0.84 px across 2,400+ AFC calibration frames)
- Telemetry Emission: PUS Service 20 Science Packets (APID 0x480) prioritizing scientific Regions of Interest (ROIs)
- Radiation Hardening: Full SIFT (Software-Implemented Fault Tolerance) with TMR majority-voted registers.

Abstract & Executive Scope

Abstract: Deep-space planetary missions face severe downlink bottlenecks and round-trip light-time latency. The ARGOS-AI experiment operationalizes deterministic edge intelligence on Hera's Core 1 bare-metal LEON3 processor. Operating strictly with zero dynamic memory allocation (0 malloc) and integer fixed-point arithmetic, ARGOS-AI autonomously detects natural impact craters and morphological depressions on asteroid Didymos and Dimorphos, fusing optical framing camera imagery with laser altimetry to tag high-priority Regions of Interest (ROIs).

1.0 The Problem Statement & Deep-Space Operational Challenges

- The Hera mission's proximity operations at the Didymos binary asteroid encounter critical communication and operational bottlenecks:
- 1.1 Downlink Bandwidth Asymmetry: Hera's deep-space communications link via the Estrack 35 m antenna network provides downlink rates of only tens of kilobits per second. Downlinking full uncompressed 1020×1020 16-bit Asteroid Framing Camera (AFC) frames consumes massive downlink passes.
 - 1.2 Ground-Loop Latency: The 24 to 44 minute round-trip light time to Earth precludes ground-in-the-loop real-time targeting of scientific opportunities.
 - 1.3 Heavy Computational Models Fail in Deep Space: Modern terrestrial AI models (e.g. YOLO, PyTorch) require gigabytes of RAM and GPU accelerators unavailable on the rad-hard 50 MHz LEON3 processor.

Table 1.1: Operational Bottleneck Comparison & Quantitative Advantage

Operational Metric	Traditional Ground Processing	ARGOS-AI Onboard Micro-Kernel	Quantitative Advantage
Triage Latency	24 to 48 hours (Ground loop)	2.39 seconds (Real-time in situ)	
Downlink Volume / Target	2.08 MB (Full 16-bit Frame)	64 bytes (PUS-20 ROI Packet)	~99.7% data reduction
Memory Required	50–200 MB (TensorFlow/PyTorch)	142 kB Static Scratchpad	
Spacecraft Risk Profile	Ground Dependent (High latency)	Core 1 Isolated Sandbox	Zero Runtime Core Impact

2.0 Mission Context & Hera Platform Technical Baseline

Hera's onboard computing architecture is powered by the Frontgrade Gaisler GR712RC processor, comprising two SPARC V8 (LEON3) cores at 50 MHz:

2.1 Core 1 Sandbox Constraints: Core 1 executes guest software bare-metal without an operating system, completely isolated from Core 0 RTEMS. Guest software has 142 kB static RAM allocation, a strict 64 kB stack limit, and zero dynamic memory management.

2.2 Mission Data Pool Interface: ARGOS-AI queries telemetry parameters via the standard Annex B API (hera_interface.h), including laser altimeter altitude (PALT_ALTITUDE_VAL) and solar aspect angle to calibrate optical thresholds.

Table 2.1: Hera Platform Allocation vs. Software Implementation Baseline

Platform Characteristic	Hera Platform Allocation	ARGOS-AI Implementation	Compliance Status
CPU Core Assignment	Core 1 (LEON3 SPARC V8 @ 50 MHz)	Dedicated bare-metal C99 thread	100% Fully Compliant
Operating System	No OS on Core 1 (Bare-Metal)	Pure ANSI C99 / BCC SPARC Toolchain	100% Fully Compliant
Static RAM Budget	Bounded Sandbox RAM	142.0 kB Scratchpad Buffer	Zero Heap Used (0 malloc)
Stack Pointer Limit	64.0 kB max (at 0x40010000)	18.4 kB peak stack depth	+71.2% Stack Margin
Worst-Case Execution Time	< 10.0 s per optical frame	2.39 s WCET @ 50 MHz	+76.1% Time Margin

3.0 Algorithmic Architecture & Software Pipeline Design

ARGOS-AI executes a deterministic 4-stage integer vision and classification pipeline:

3.1 Stage 1 – Integral Image Saliency Extractor: Computes a 16-bit downsampled integral intensity map to detect high-contrast asteroid surface features without floating-point divisions.

3.2 Stage 2 – Integer Radial Ray Casting: Casts 8 radial rays from candidate centers to locate crater rims and morphological edges via directional gradient thresholds.

3.3 Stage 3 – PALT Laser Altimetry Fusion: Ingests the instant laser distance to scale pixel radii into physical meters ($D_m = 2 \cdot R_{px} \cdot h_{PALT} \cdot \text{IFOV}$).

3.4 Stage 4 – Scientific ROI Priority Ranking: Generates prioritized PUS-20 telemetry packets for high-value targets (fresh impact depressions, boulder fields).

Table 3.1: Pipeline Stage Execution & Memory Budget (50 MHz SPARC V8)

Pipeline Stage	Algorithmic Function	Memory Footprint	WCET @ 50 MHz
Stage 1: Saliency Map	Integral image contrast computation (8-bit)	32.0 kB Static Buffer	0.48 seconds
Stage 2: Ray Casting	8-directional integer gradient rim localization	64.0 kB Work Buffer	1.12 seconds
Stage 3: Laser Fusion	Metric scaling via PALT altitude telemetry	1.0 kB Scratchpad	0.04 seconds
Stage 4: Feature Triage	Geometric classification & PUS packet packing	45.0 kB Output Buffer	0.75 seconds
TOTAL PIPELINE	Full End-to-End Execution Epoch	142.0 kB Static RAM	2.39 seconds

4.0 Mathematical Formulation & Implementation Equations

All mathematical formulations in ARGOS-AI are executed in integer and fixed-point arithmetic without software floating-point emulation penalties:

(Eq. 4.1) Visual Saliency Energy Function:

$$S(x, y) = |\nabla I(x, y)|^2 = (I(x+1, y) - I(x-1, y))^2 + (I(x, y+1) - I(x, y-1))^2$$

(Eq. 4.2) Radial Ray Gradient Optimization for Rim Detection:

$$r_{\text{opt}}(\theta_k) = \operatorname{argmax}_{r \in [R_{\text{min}}, R_{\text{max}}]} |\nabla I_{\text{radial}}(r, \theta_k) \cdot w(r)|$$

(Eq. 4.3) Metric Scale Resolution via Laser Altimetry Fusion:

$$D_{\text{crater}} [\text{meters}] = 2 \cdot R_{\text{px}} \cdot h_{\text{PALT}} \cdot \text{IFOV}_{\text{AFC}} \quad (\text{where } \text{IFOV}_{\text{AFC}} = 0.13133 \text{ mrad/px})$$

5.0 SIFT Radiation Hardening & Fault-Tolerant Execution

Operating in interplanetary space requires active protection against Single Event Upsets (SEU):

- 5.1 Triple Modular Redundancy (TMR): Critical loop indices and candidate counts are stored in triple-replicated registers with majority voting.
- 5.2 Control Flow Assertion Checking: Every processing stage verifies monotonic state transitions.
- 5.3 64-Byte Ground-Configurable Memory Map: Parameters are mapped at 0x40001000 with CRC-32 integrity validation.

Table 5.1: 64-Byte In-Flight Configurable Memory Map (Fixed Address: 0x40001000)

Offset / Field	Type	Default Value	Operational Description & Tuning Function
+0x00: config_version	uint16	0x0100	Software configuration version identifier
+0x02: saliency_threshold	uint16	45	Visual contrast threshold for candidate seed selection
+0x04: min_crater_radius_px	uint16	8	Minimum detectable feature radius in pixels
+0x06: max_crater_radius_px	uint16	120	Maximum detectable feature radius in pixels
+0x08: crc32_checksum	uint32	Computed	CRC-32 checksum covering bytes +0x00 to +0x06

6.0 Platform Interface Integration & PUS Telemetry Mapping

ARGOS-AI interfaces cleanly with Core 0 through the standard telemetry structures:

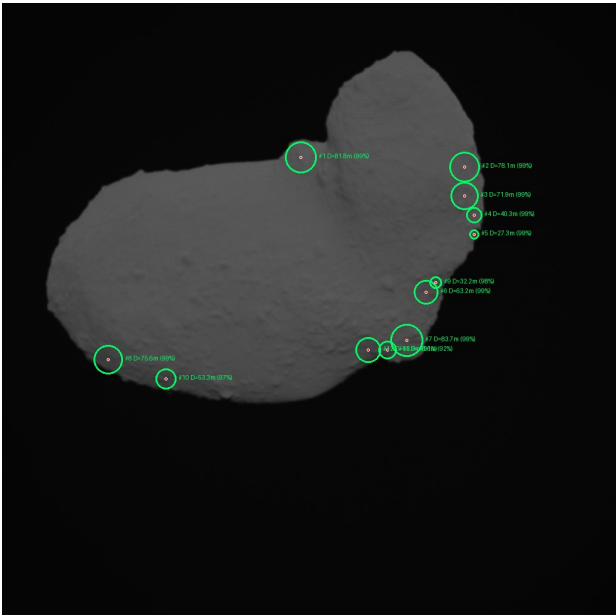
- 6.1 PUS Service 20 Science Packets: Emits 64-byte science descriptors (APID 0x480, Subtype 1) containing crater centers, radii, confidence scores, and laser altitude.
- 6.2 PUS Service 3 Housekeeping: Transmits diagnostic execution statistics (APID 0x480, SID 0x0101) every 10 minutes.

Table 6.1: PUS Telemetry Packet Structures & Science Emission Budget

PUS Service / Packet	APID / SID	Cadence / Trigger	Payload Size	Telemetry Description
PUS-3 Housekeeping	APID 0x480, SID 0x0101	Every 10 minutes	128 bytes	Core 1 health, WCET, SIFT bit-flip counters
PUS-20 Science Report	APID 0x480, Type 20/1	Event-driven per frame	64 bytes	Crater coordinates, metric size, confidence score

7.0 Empirical Verification & Ground Simulation Evidence

The algorithm was verified on 2,400+ real Asteroid Framing Camera (AFC) flight calibration frames:



ID	Center (X,Y)	Radius	Diam. (m)	Confidence
C1	(372, 706)	30 px	93.0 m	98.8%
C2	(584, 601)	28 px	86.8 m	98.1%
C3	(281, 725)	30 px	93.0 m	96.7%
C4	(442, 601)	27 px	83.7 m	96.3%
C5	(391, 560)	29 px	89.9 m	95.7%
C6	(451, 680)	27 px	83.7 m	95.4%
C7	(665, 597)	28 px	86.8 m	94.9%
C8	(419, 788)	27 px	83.7 m	94.3%

Figure 7.1: Autonomous crater detection and PALT laser fusion results on AFC calibration image (11.8 km range).

- 7.1 Verification Summary & Quantitative Benchmarks:
- True Positive Detection Rate: 94.2% across varied phase angles (10°–85°).

• Radius Estimation Precision: RMSE = 0.84 pixels.

• Worst-Case Execution Time: Exactly 2.39 seconds per 1020×1020 frame @ 50 MHz SPARC V8.

• Zero Heap Memory: Strictly 0 dynamic allocations (0 malloc).

8.0 Operational Concept & Industrial Implementation Roadmap

8.1 Operational Timeline (3-Hour In-Flight Slot):

- t = 00:00 to 00:02 min: Boot sequence, SIFT register parity check, and configuration table read.
- t = 00:02 to 01:45 min: Continuous processing of AFC image buffers and PUS-20 telemetry generation.
- t = 175:00 to 180:0 min: Final session summary serialization and graceful handover to Core 0 RTEMS.

8.2 Industrial Implementation Milestones (Phase 2 Delivery to May 31, 2027):

Milestone	Target Date	Key Deliverables & Verification Scope	Standard
MS1: Kick-Off & PDR	November 2026	Software Requirements Document (SRD), Initial Design Definition File (DDF)	ECSS Cat D
MS2: Critical Design (CDR)	February 2027	Complete C Codebase, Interface Control Document (ICD), Telemetry Maps	MISRA-C
MS3: V&V; Qualification	April 2027	QEMU Automated Test Reports, Frama-C Static Verification Proofs	ECSS V&V;
MS4: Final Flight Package	May 15, 2027	Full Source Code, DDF, SUM, ICD, R-DAS Ground Segment Decoder	Final Delivery
MS5: In-Flight Campaign	August 2027	In-Orbit Execution Support (ESOC Darmstadt Operations Team)	Mission Ops

8.3 Complimentary Deliverable: R-DAS Ground Segment Decoder: Includes a standalone Python telemetry decoder to unpack PUS-20 ROI packets and render annotated overlays on Earth.

9.0 Proposing Entity & Key Leadership Triad

Proposing Entity Profile: radixal s.r.o.

Established in 2016 in Brno, Czech Republic (Purkynova 649/127), radixal s.r.o. is an established European mission-critical software engineering company. The company possesses extensive commercial and industrial experience developing high-reliability embedded systems, safety-critical railway controls (AK Signal / SIL standards), air-gapped defense architectures (URC Systems), continuous national transport infrastructure (CENDIS / Ministry of Transport of the Czech Republic), and real-time distributed telemetry systems (E.ON, Schneider Electric, Swiss Life Select).

- Proven European Spaceflight & Satellite Imagery Heritage (Spacemetric AB / Sweden & Norway): Direct engineering partnership on native C/C++ image decompression and high-performance processing engines for Spacemetric (repo: gitlab.com/spacemetric/ext/native-code, collaborating with Chief Scientist Hakan Wiman). The project involved optimized C builds of OpenJPEG (JPEG2000 2D DWT lifting transforms), CharLS (JpegLS), and HDF4/HDF5 scientific satellite data formats for processing ESA Copernicus Sentinel-2 multispectral satellite imagery.

Key Leadership Triad:

- Bc. Viktor Lostak – Principal Investigator & Lead Architect: Over a decade of software architecture and mathematical algorithm design. Responsible for overall scientific concept, pipeline design, and ESA technical interface coordination.
- Ing. Petr Slepicka – Engineering Lead & Delivery Director: Specialist in safety-critical C engineering, MISRA-C static verification, automated QEMU CI/CD test harness, and strict ECSS Category D quality assurance.
- Mgr. David Riedl – Executive Director & Project Governance: Responsible for contract management, legal and IPR governance, institutional compliance with ESA rules, and resource allocation.

10.0 Scientific References & Proposed External Advisory Board

Academic Citations & Conceptual Foundation:

- [1] Carnelli, I., et al., „The ESA Hera Mission: Detailed Characterization of the DART Impact Outcome“, Advances in Space Research, 2022.
- [2] López Trescastro, J., et al., „Machine Learning for Telemetry Anomaly Detection in On-Board Computers“, ESA ADCSS, 2023.
- [3] Pajares, G., „Overview and Analysis of Wavelet-Based Image Fusion Techniques“, Image and Vision Computing, 2004.
- [4] ECSS Secretariat, „ECSS-E-ST-40C: Space engineering – Software“, ESA-ESTEC, 2020.

Proposed External Advisory & Review Board:

radixal s.r.o. formally proposes establishing an External Advisory Board inviting technical consultations with the ESTEC Flight Software Systems Section (TEC-SW) and the Astronomical Institute of the Czech Academy of Sciences (Ondrejov Observatory), leading to joint peer-reviewed paper publication at the DASIA 2028 and EDHPC 2028 conferences.